a replacement of British imperial rule' and that as such '[i]t was focused on transfer of political power'. Pritam Singh continues, 'There is ample historical evidence to show that Gandhi was even willing to accept a subordinate dominion status for India under the broad structure of imperial rule.' This is a perspective to which Justice Markandey Katju has recently added his voice. Gandhi was opposed in this by Subhas Chandra Bose from within the Congress Party itself, and as Pritam Singh observes, he was opposed 'in muted voices even from Nehru', but it is nevertheless Gandhism that has prevailed and become the popular narrative of the Indian Independence movement to the exclusion of all else.

The reason for Gandhi's 'compromising stance towards British imperialism was the serious involvement of the top layers of India's capitalist class (Birla, Purushottamdas Thakurdass, and Walchand Hirachand etc.) in the influencing of, if not making of, the Gandhian and Congress perspective.' These major Indian industrialists, who formed the backbone of the Indian economy, had curried much favour during the years of the British Raj and did not wish to see the goose that laid the golden egg for them put so peremptorily to death. If there were reasons for Gandhi's moderation, they were entirely practical and self-serving and not noble, as the popular image of the salt marches and ahimsa (non-violence) have come to denote over the last hundred years. This is echoed by the noted Bhagat Singh specialist, Chaman Lal, who has referred to the 'moral indictment of Gandhian principles' when alluding to the 'national bourgeoisie interests involved' so that '[e]veryone knows that Gandhi was very close to business magnate, G.D. Birla' and that 'much of the funds for the Congress Party came from business houses . . .'.[6] Chaman Lal even goes further, however. Lord Irwin's biography itself, he points out, shows him in the following position:

> Irwin says that during their discussion of the Bhagat Singh issue Gandhi had asked him if he would mind if he (Gandhi) publicly claimed that he put a lot of pressure on the Viceroy on this issue. Irwin had replied that he wouldn't mind that. So "the best efforts" made by Gandhi "to save the lives of Bhagat Singh" and his comrades, were planned with full knowledge of the British administration.[7]